

("which I still consider a small town"), says: "It gives a rawness to the characters and a freshness to the viewers." The lead of *Raja ki Aayegi Baraat*, Anjali Abrol, was auditioned in Jammu and the show is produced by first-timer Rashmi Sharma, a former script co-ordinator. The move beyond Tulsi's saris and Parvati's tears is in keeping with recent re-

too high-end, compared to the six-city average of 49 per cent.

It is these small towns that channels are eyeing hungrily. "Most cable audience growth is coming from towns with less than one lakh population," says Keertan Adhyanthaya, executive vice-president, Star Plus. The figures prove it. With the cable households growing from 41 million in 2002 to 68 million, the growth has come from towns with population of less than one million (from 70 per cent to 72 per cent) and more than one million (8 per cent to 9 per cent). In contrast, the growth of cable households in metros has declined from 23 per cent to 19 per cent. The special targeting is working: for Star Plus, 60 per

does—work only as a catalyst. "It distinguishes one serial from another, with specific festivals, costumes and language." His channel's growth path backs his hypothesis. Zee TV's growth has come primarily from metros—between the first two and last two quarters of 2007, metro ratings have gone up by 38 per cent while those in non-metros have gone up by only 22 per cent. For Star Plus though, the small town effect is not only about having the Taj Mahal as the backdrop in *Bidaai*. It's about details such as what to wear (*parandis* and *phulkari* in the forthcoming *Grihasti* based in Punjab) as well as what to celebrate (Durga pujas in *Karam Apna Apna*). Will it be enough to retain loyal viewers? Minal



LOCAL FLAVOUR: The Bengal-based *Ardhangini* and the daughters of Punjab in *Maayka* (right), both on Zee TV

search commissioned by Starcom Worldwide and undertaken by Hansa Research across 1,562 respondents between 18 and 54 in socio-economic categories A, B, and C in six-key television viewing centres (Mumbai, Delhi, Ahmedabad, Bhopal, Kolhapur, and Moradabad), which suggests that nine out of 10 television viewers want a change from the *saas-bahu* soaps—in Moradabad the percentage was 90.2 per cent, in Kolhapur it was 59.6 per cent, and in Bhopal, it was 67 per cent. Over 50 per cent of respondents expressed confusion about the story lines of these serials. Moreover, 60 per cent of respondents in Kolhapur and Moradabad said the current serials are

cent of the audience share of *Bidaai* came from the Hindi heartland, while 59 per cent of the audience share of the Gujarati-dominated *Baa Bahoo Aur Baby* comes from Gujarat and Maharashtra.

It's a formula that new channels are quickly trying to clone, trying to do away with rapes, kidnappings and third marriages. Star One, launched three years ago for the 25 to 40-year-old big city viewer, has now been repositioned with shows such as *Chhoona Hai Aasman*, which celebrate small town chutzpah. Ashish Kaul, executive vice-president, Zee TV, believes the small town syndrome can—and

Hazarika, a Delhi viewer forum analyst, is already disappointed: "These serials are used merely to hook the small town girls. They begin as role models for them and end up as a treatise on how to hook a rich husband and then how to keep him within the political strife of a joint family. It's just regional tokenism."

It's also sheer survival. The general entertainment category has shrunk from 21.3 per cent of the television viewing universe in 2004 to 20.2 per cent in 2007. With the new copy-paste culture—try spotting the difference between new entrants like 9X and older ones—the leaders have to innovate, in substance, not style alone. ■